

Executive Functioning IEP Goal Bank

A practical drafting desk for EF goals: pick the skill, match the grade band, choose the data method, then customize the goal from the student's baseline.

[Start Here](#)[Browse Goals](#)[Pick Data Method](#)

IEP USE BOUNDARY

These goals are informational examples. IDEA requires IEP goals to be individualized from the student's PLAAFP, evaluation data, baseline performance, disability-related needs, and IEP team decisions. Do not copy a goal into a legally binding IEP without adapting the condition, behavior, criterion, and measurement method to the student's documented baseline.

QUICK START

Build A Better EF Goal In Four Moves

Most weak EF goals fail because they skip the baseline or use vague measurement. Use this sequence before browsing examples.

1. Name The Skill

Choose the EF demand that is actually blocking access: initiation, planning, organization, time, memory, flexibility, monitoring, regulation, inhibition, attention, or persistence.

2. Add Baseline

Anchor the goal in PLAAFP data: current prompt level, latency, missing-work rate, rubric score, completion percentage, or observed frequency.

3. Pick A Scaffold

Write the support into the condition: checklist, visual timer, planner, graphic organizer, self-rating rubric, or digital calendar.

4. Choose Data

Decide how the team will measure it before the goal is finalized. If no one can collect the data, the goal is not ready.

GOAL FORMULA

Given [condition/scaffold], **the student will** [observable EF behavior], **to** [criterion], **as measured by** [specific data source] **over** [review period].

[Copy Goal Formula](#)

PROBLEM FINDER

Start With The School Problem

If you do not know the EF domain yet, start with the observable classroom problem. These buttons jump straight to the most likely goal area.

Won't Start Work

Look at latency, prompt dependence, and first-step behavior.

[Open Task Initiation](#)

Lost Or Missing Assignments

Look at systems for materials, portals, folders, and turn-in routines.

[Open Organization](#)

Underestimates Time

Look at estimation, pacing, transitions, and multi-day deadlines.

Open Time Management

Forgets Directions

Look at verbal instruction load, note capture, and external memory supports.

Open Working Memory

Melts Down Or Shuts Down

Look at feedback tolerance, frustration recovery, and request-for-break skills.

Open Emotional Regulation

Rushes, Blurts, Or Clicks Away

Look at inhibition, pause routines, and impulse control in the actual setting.

Open Impulse Control

DEVELOPMENTAL FIT

Match The Goal To The Student's Age And Support Level

Executive functions develop gradually into early adulthood. The same domain should look different in elementary school, middle school, and transition planning.

Elementary

Use external scaffolds in the condition: visual schedules, countdown timers, first/then supports, adult prompts, checklists, and concrete materials.

Middle School

Shift the work toward student-operated tools: planners, chunking sheets, binder systems, error checks, strategy selection, and self-monitoring prompts.

High School

Connect EF goals to transition requirements: independent scheduling, self-advocacy, work readiness, accommodation use, and long-term persistence.

GOAL BANK

Sample Executive Functioning IEP Goals By Domain

Each example includes a scaffolded condition, observable behavior, mastery criterion, and progress-monitoring method.

Task Initiation



Use when: the issue is delay between direction and first action, not whether the student understands the assignment.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	Given a verbal directive and a 3-minute visual timer, the student will gather materials and begin the assigned task within 2 minutes in 4 of 5 opportunities.	Latency recording.
Middle	Upon receiving a multi-step written assignment, the student will highlight the first required step and	Teacher rubric and work-sample review.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
	begin work within 5 minutes in 4 of 5 observed instances.	
High	When assigned a long-term project, the student will create an initial milestone and identify needed materials within 24 hours across 3 consecutive projects.	Milestone checklist audit.

Planning And Prioritization



Use when: the student becomes overloaded by multi-step work, due dates, or deciding what matters first.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	Given a 3-step academic task and graphic organizer, the student will sequence required steps before beginning with 90% accuracy across 5 trials.	Trial-by-trial sequencing data.
Middle	Given homework across subjects, the student will rank assignments by due date and difficulty for 80% of assignments over 6 weeks.	Weekly prioritization matrix review.
High	Upon receiving a syllabus, the student will transfer major exams and project deadlines into a digital	Case manager calendar audit.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
	calendar within 3 days with 100% accuracy.	

Organization +

Use when: materials, digital files, notes, or ideas are not reliably findable at the point of performance.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	During dismissal, the student will use a visual checklist to pack required folders, homework, and personal items with 80% accuracy across 4 weeks.	End-of-day checklist.
Middle	Using a color-coded folder system, the student will file notes, handouts, and graded work into the correct subject location with 90% accuracy.	Biweekly binder check rubric.
High	Across multiple digital platforms, the student will upload completed assignments to the correct portal while maintaining a missing-assignment rate below 10%.	LMS and gradebook audit.

Time Management +

Use when: the student misjudges duration, misses deadlines, arrives late, or cannot pace work across time.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	Given a worksheet and visual timer, the student will complete the assignment before the timer expires on 4 of 5 assignments with no more than 1 reminder.	Completion sheet and time log.
Middle	Given a 2-week assignment, the student will chunk the work into daily sections and assign self-imposed due dates on 3 consecutive long-term tasks.	Chunking worksheet review.
High	When managing nightly homework, the student will estimate task duration, record actual completion time, and compare estimates to actuals with 80% log fidelity over 4 weeks.	Time-tracking logs.

Working Memory



Use when: the student loses instructions, task rules, numbers, or source details while trying to use them.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	Given a 3-step verbal directive, the student will	Naturalistic probe sheet.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
	execute all steps in order without repeated instruction in 4 of 5 observed trials.	
Middle	During multi-step word problems, the student will use a scratchpad or organizer to document needed numbers and operations in 8 of 10 problems.	Permanent product analysis.
High	Given oral instructions over a 20-minute period, the student will independently write down 90% of core deliverables across 5 observed sessions.	Comparison of notes to teacher directives.

Cognitive Flexibility



Use when: the student gets stuck after changes, errors, failed strategies, or competing perspectives.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	When a routine changes, the student will transition to the new activity without protesting or maladaptive behavior within 2 minutes in 4 of 5 occurrences.	ABC data collection.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Middle	When a math strategy fails, the student will select an alternative strategy on 4 of 5 observed occasions.	Teacher observation and work-process analysis.
High	When encountering a scheduling conflict or missing material, the student will generate 2 viable alternatives and enact one in 90% of observed instances.	Reflection log or case manager interview.

Self-Monitoring And Metacognition



Use when: the student does not notice errors, missing work, performance patterns, or needed accommodations without support.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	Before submitting independent work, the student will use a visual checklist to verify name and completion on 8 of 10 assignments.	Checklist and worksheet review.
Middle	After graded assessments, the student will chart the score, identify an error pattern, and write one goal for the next assessment across the semester.	Data-tracking portfolio.
High	Given a complex project, the student will use a self-	Student-teacher rubric comparison.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
	monitoring rubric before submission and score within 10% of the teacher's final rubric score on 4 of 5 major assignments.	

Emotional Regulation

+

Use when: frustration, anxiety, feedback, or overwhelm interrupts access to instruction or task completion.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	When frustrated by academic work, the student will identify an emotional state using a visual tool and request a break before escalation in 4 of 5 instances.	Self-advocacy requests versus outburst frequency.
Middle	Upon receiving corrective feedback, the student will refrain from shutdown or aggression and ask one clarifying question in 4 of 5 instances.	Teacher observation log.
High	During high-stress academic periods, the student will implement a stress-tolerance routine 3 times per week and document strategy use.	Digital tracker or weekly self-reflection.

Impulse Control / Response Inhibition



Use when: the target is pausing before blurting, touching, guessing, tab-switching, posting, or reacting.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	During whole-class instruction, the student will raise a hand and wait to be called on, reducing blurts to fewer than 3 per 20-minute block.	Frequency tally.
Middle	When using a device for academic work, the student will remain on approved applications for 90% of the technology block across 5 sessions.	Digital monitoring logs.
High	During debates or group discussions, the student will wait until the speaker finishes before responding, with zero interruptions across 5 observation days.	Momentary time sampling.

Sustained Attention / Task Persistence



Use when: the student can start but cannot maintain focus or effort through low-interest, long, or distracting tasks.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	During 15 minutes of independent reading, the	Momentary time sampling.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
	student will remain seated and visually focused for at least 12 minutes across 4 sessions.	
Middle	During direct instruction, the student will maintain active attention through note-taking or speaker tracking for 80% of observed intervals over 2 weeks.	Partial-interval recording.
High	Given an extended reading assignment, the student will read in 20-minute blocks with planned breaks and score 80% or higher on comprehension checks.	Reading log plus academic performance.

Goal-Directed Persistence



Use when: the target requires sustained follow-through toward a delayed academic, transition, work, or independence outcome.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
Elementary	When given a weekly target, the student will persist in daily activities needed to meet the Friday target in 3 of 4 consecutive weeks.	Token, reading, or classroom job log.
Middle	Over an academic quarter, the student will track a challenging class grade	Attendance and gradebook review.

Level	Sample Goal	Measure
	and attend 90% of scheduled interventions to improve from baseline.	
High	During transition planning, the student will identify a college, career, or independent-living objective and complete required prerequisite steps by the transition timeline.	Milestone and document review.

PROGRESS MONITORING

Choose The Data Method Before Finalizing The Goal

A measurable EF goal needs more than "teacher observation." Select a method that matches the behavior.

Method	Best For	Example Use
Permanent product analysis	Organization, planning, self-monitoring, written work.	Review a completed graphic organizer, planner, LMS submission, or self-check rubric.
Momentary time sampling / interval recording	Sustained attention, task persistence, discussion participation.	Record whether the target behavior is present at set intervals during a class block.
Latency recording	Task initiation, transitions, return to baseline after frustration.	Measure time from prompt or assignment delivery to first observable work behavior.

Method	Best For	Example Use
Frequency / tally data	Impulse control, interruptions, prompts, self-advocacy requests.	Count verbal blurts, adult reminders, or independent help requests during a defined period.
Self-assessment rubric	Metacognition, self-advocacy, persistence, high-school transition skills.	Compare the student's self-rating to teacher, case manager, or work-site feedback.

LEGAL GUARDRAILS

Make The Goal Defensible

Executive functioning is usually addressed through eligibility categories such as OHI, SLD, ASD, or TBI. The goal still needs direct connection to documented educational impact.

Start With PLAAFP

The present levels section should name the EF deficit and baseline data. Without baseline data, the annual goal is arbitrary.

Use Andrew F. Logic

The goal should be reasonably calculated for progress appropriate in light of the student's circumstances, not minimal or stagnant progress.

Implementation Matters

If an EF tool, tracker, or accommodation is written into the IEP, inconsistent implementation can create compliance risk.

DRAFTING CHECK

Before adopting any goal, ask: What baseline proves this need? What support is built into the condition? What behavior can be seen or reviewed? What criterion defines mastery? What data method will be used consistently?

Copy Drafting Check

Research And Source Trail



BRIEF-2 executive function rating inventory overview(<https://www.parinc.com/products/BRIEF-2>)

- ✓ **Understood: core executive function skill** (<https://www.understood.org/en/articles/types-of-executive-function-skills>)
- ✓ **Wrightslaw: SMART IEP goal planning**(https://www.wrightslaw.com/advoc/articles/plan_iep_goals.html)
- ✓ **Center for Parent Information and Resources: transition goals in the IEP** (<https://www.parentcenterhub.org/transition-goals/>)
- ✓ **Canonical executive function maturation trajectory research** (<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10616171/>)
- ✓ **Open ExEF citations and broader source directory**